

ANI

TANGLED UP CM Devendra Fadnavis with his deputy Eknath Shinde

took two NCP members into custody based on the kidnapping plaint.

The detention of two members, and the added benefit of defection by three NCP and two Sena members, ensured the BJP's Priya Shinde was elected the ZP president, defeating the NCP's Manisha Phadtare. An incensed Desai, the guardian minister of Satara who was hurt in the fracas, warned that he would take the fight with the BJP to its logical end. In the legislative council, he charged that it was unprecedented for a minister to be manhandled by the police and that SP Tushar Doshi had behaved like a "domestic servant". Council deputy chairperson Neelam Gorhe directed that Doshi and his juniors be suspended—an order stayed later by the BJP council chairman Ram Shinde!

Takeaways

- **Satara local body poll turns heated with allies BJP on one side, NCP-Sena on the other**
- **Protests in legislature, but Shinde-Fadnavis meeting smooths things over**
- **Shinde Sena is said to have a 'Fadnavis Sena' within it, a caucus more loyal to the CM**

FRAGILE CEASEFIRE

Sena and NCP MLAs soon scaled up their protests on the steps of the state legislature. Inside, during the budget session, chief minister Devendra Fadnavis sought to calm the waters, promising an inquiry and appropriate action (SP Doshi was later sent on leave). Desai and Patil also threatened to resign from the cabinet, but then deputy CM Eknath Shinde met Fadnavis, and an understanding was struck. The reasons for the grouse linger on, though.

The BJP-Shinde Sena conflict has another angle, says a senior leader of the rival Shiv Sena (Uddhav Balasaheb Thackeray). The present flare-up coincided with the deputy CM's visit to New Delhi to meet Prime Minister Narendra Modi, amid rumours that he would launch 'Operation Tiger' to engineer defections from the nine Lok Sabha MPs of the Sena (UBT). The BJP is eager to get any UBT rebels on its side rather than allow Shinde to strengthen himself. The talk is that the Shinde Sena has a "Fadnavis Sena" within it, a caucus more loyal to the CM. Similarly, some NCP MLAs too are said to be sitting on the fence after being wooed by the BJP. This could be a short intermission. ■

▶ UTTARAKHAND

THE NEW

The hill state gets a high-level pa

By **Avaneesh Mishra**



EVEN AN EYE WITH ATTENTION DEFICIT may have noticed a pattern here. For, a series of recent decisions etc. in Uttarakhand have centred on questions of identity and community. Integrating all of that is a new move by the BJP-led state government: a high-level committee to study the status of minorities. Prima facie, it is an empirical exercise, a benevolent one that recalls the famous Sachar Committee of 2005-06. Its time and place have drawn attention, though. Uttarakhand, which passed India's first Uniform Civil Code (UCC) in 2023, is a frontline Hindutva state now. Also, an assembly election is due next year, as is the prefatory Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls.

The focus, too, differs a bit. The seven-member panel, which brings together jurists, ex-bureaucrats, academics and minority representatives, will, of course, do a comprehensive study of the socio-economic, educational and cultural shifts within the minority communities over the past 25 years (practically since the state's formation). But it will also study demographics and assess 'compliance' with constitutional norms, recommending policy or legal interventions if gaps are identified.

Chaired by retired Justice Akhilesh Chand Sharma, the panel includes retired IAS officer Shatrughan Singh, Doon University vice-chancellor Surekha